

Parasitic plants



Mistletoe

The plants take root on branches, from seeds dropped by birds that eat mistletoe berries.



Dodder

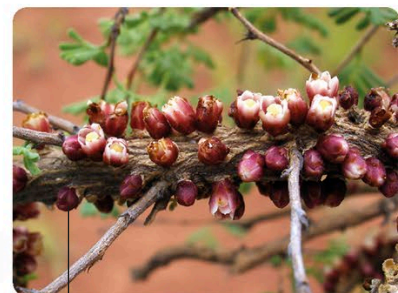
Thin stems wrap around a host plant and weaken its immune system.



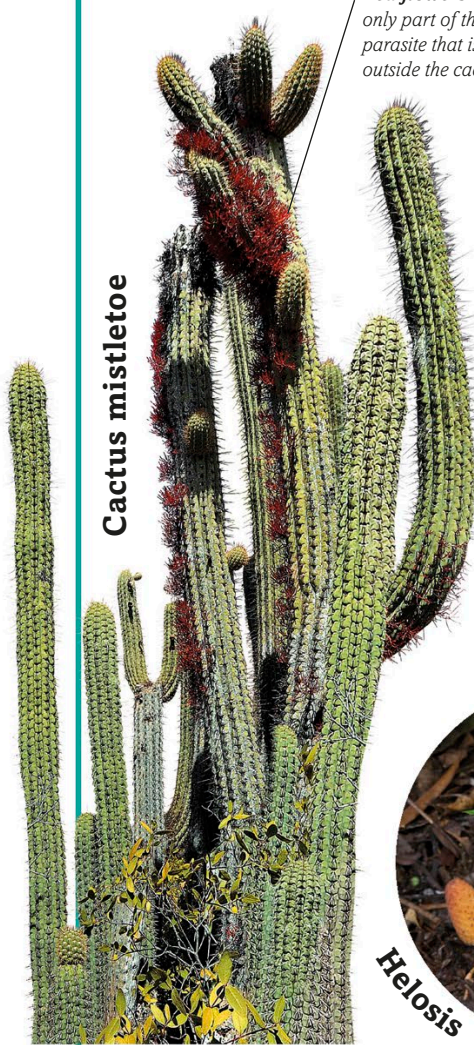
The pale stems of this plant are parasites of ivy plants.



Thurber's stemsucker



Tiny flowers, 2 mm across, bloom along the host stem.



Cactus mistletoe

Red flowers are the only part of this leafless parasite that is visible outside the cactus.

Mushroom-shaped flower stalks emerge from underground stems, which feed on the roots of host plants.



Helosis



Ivy broomrape

Most plants absorb water and nutrients from the soil to make their own food using energy from sunlight, but others have developed sneakier ways to survive. Parasitic plants pierce the stems or roots of other plants to steal their hard-earned supplies.

There are two main types of parasitic plants. Hemiparasites (half parasites) can use sunlight to make some of their own food but absorb water, nutrients, and sometimes sugars from the host plants they live on. Some hemiparasites, such as **mistletoe** and the **Australian Christmas tree**, will